after the deposition of Mullah Shakur. It was clear, he noted, that the Shah had ‘a deep-rooted jealousy against the [new] Wazir’.

> The King gave me at great length his feelings and his sufferings. He said he had not a trustworthy man in his country; that all were engaged in setting him against us, and us against him – that his enemies were allowed to continue in power – that the portion of his revenue set aside for him was not collected and paid – that his adherents were discontented – that he was kept under by us in all things, yet that they had not gone right; that a pilgrimage to Mecca was his only alternative [in other words, that he should abdicate], and that at Ludhiana he had much power as compared with this part of his reign.[45]

But Burnes had never taken to Shuja, or rated his abilities, and was in no mood to begin feeling sympathy now. Moreover, his boss was belatedly coming to agree. ‘An expression from Macnaghten today that Shah Shuja was an old woman, not fit to rule this people, with divers other condemnations,’ wrote Burnes in one letter. ‘Ay – see my *Travels* [*into Bokara*], and as far back as 1831, ten years ago. Still, I look upon his fitness or unfitness as very immaterial; we are here to govern for him, and govern we must.’[46]

Just how badly Nizam al-Daula handled the Afghan nobility became apparent shortly afterwards. At the end of August 1841, Macnaghten received a despatch from Auckland telling him that the financial breaking point had now been reached: the Company had been forced to take out a £5 million loan from Indian merchants at exorbitant rates of interest just to continue paying salaries.[47] Macnaghten was ordered to make extensive and immediate cuts to expenditure. Moreover, in London a Tory government had just come to power by one vote, and the new Prime Minister, Sir Robert Peel, showed no wish to continue financing what he and his colleagues regarded as one of Lord Palmerston’s expensive and unnecessary Whig wars.[48] Auckland, a Whig political appointee, was now seriously considering his resignation. Macnaghten was aghast: ‘If they – the Tories – deprive the Shah altogether of our support I have no hesitation of saying they will commit an unparalleled political atrocity.’ It would not only be a breach of a treaty but a ‘cheat of the first magnitude’.[49]

To Auckland, Macnaghten wrote in a rare protest: ‘I cannot help feeling some surprise at these repeated communications [asking for more cuts] after the many expositions I have given of the wretched state of the finances of